

Asclepius 21–29

Codex Reference: VI,8

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Editor's Introduction

The Hermetic tractate *Asclepius* was composed in Greek but exists in complete form only in a Latin translation. It was originally called *The Perfect Teaching*. VI,8 is a Coptic translation of a large selection from the middle portion of the tractate. It differs from the Latin at many points, but is still recognizably from the same source as the Latin because of the similarity of contents and the way they are ordered. Two Greek passages from the middle section of *Asclepius* have survived, and VI,8 is stylistically closer to them than to the rather expansive and rhetorical Latin.

VI,8 has no title, either at the beginning or the end, which makes it unique in the codex. It has been suggested that a title might have been erased at the beginning of the tractate and replaced by the scribal note, which is found there, but close examination of the manuscript shows that to be unlikely. Since the scribal note suggests that *The Prayer of Thanksgiving* (VI,7) is the copyist's insertion, it is possible that VI,8 may originally have been a continuation of VI,6 (*Disc.* 8–9). In that event, the now lost title of VI,6 could have served for it as well.

The tractate is in the form of a dialogue between an Hermetic initiate, Asclepius (two others, Tat and Amon, are mentioned in 72,30–31), and the mystagogue, Trismegistus (designated as Hermes in other Hermetic tractates). *Asclepius* as a whole was probably used in an instructional-cultic context (see introduction to VI,6). The contents are arranged in five general areas.

1) 65,15–37. The mystery experience (here undescribed) is likened to sexual intercourse, in that it requires an intimate interaction between two parties in which (according to Trismegistus' view) each receives something from the other.

2) 65,37–68,19. Discussion of the separation between the pious and the impious, with the former being distinguished by having learning and knowledge, and the latter, ignorance. Man needs learning and knowledge to restrain harmful passions and to become good and immortal. Indeed, with learning and knowledge man becomes better than the gods, since then he is both mortal and immortal.

3) 68,20–70,2. Trismegistus argues that men create gods according to human likenesses.

4) 70,3. This marks the beginning of the apocalyptic section. It seems to extend only to 74,6, in contrast to the Latin *Asclepius*, where it clearly continues through 331,11 (parallel to 74,11). Here are described the woes that will come upon Egypt and the final action of the creator god to end them and bring the universe to birth. This section was probably originally independent. There are a significant number of parallels to Egyptian conceptions, which can be traced back to the Ptolemaic period and before. But parallels are also found to Plato, Stoicism, the Sibylline Oracles, and the New Testament. Some have held that the apocalypse was originally a Jewish writing, while others suggest that it was originally Egyptian because of the greater number and

antiquity of these parallels. The two concepts need not be mutually exclusive in view of the large, ancient, and literarily active Jewish community in Egypt.

5) 74,7–78,42. Discussion of the ultimate fate of the individual. The restoration of the nature of the pious ones is founded upon the eternal will of God, which expresses itself in the design of the good universe. The plan of the universe is then described. The “heights of heaven” are controlled by God. Other areas, including the earth, are controlled by other gods. Every person must go to the city in the west (place of the dead?). The soul separates from the body and goes to “the middle of the air” to be judged by the great daimon, who determines reward or punishment.

The Latin *Asclepius* is one of a group of Hermetic tractates that stands between those Hermetic tractates that are pantheistic, and hence distinctively Hellenistic, and those that are dualistic. The tractates in this group contain a mixture of both emphases. In addition to *Asclepius* they are *Corp. Herm.* IX, X, and XII. The excerpt from *Asclepius* that is VI,8 has both pantheism and dualism. The pantheism is explicitly expressed in 75,10–11 (“He [God] is in every place, and he looks out over every place.”). It can also be seen in the conviction that the universe is good (74,33–36) and that the demiurge and the earth goddess are beneficent (75,13–24), as well as in the panegyric on Egypt (70,3–9). The dualism is found in the discussion of the two natures of man (66,9–67,34), but whether this should be attributed to Gnosticism, as some have thought, or is merely an expression of the dualism common in the Graeco-Roman world generally, is not clear.

The pantheism mentioned above, with its positive evaluation of the world, has presented a problem for those who assume that Codex VI, as a collection, had its origin among Gnostics. It has been suggested that perhaps the pantheistic parts were disregarded by the collector, who was interested in the dualism. The pantheistic elements, however, could have been deleted. It seems better to suppose that the codex may not have had its origin among Gnostics. Among its eight tractates, it contains two other Hermetic pieces (tractates 6 and 7), a garbled selection from Plato’s *Republic* (tractate 5), a non-gnostic account of apostolic activity (tractate 1), and a tractate that has no clear indication of gnostic influence (tractate 2). Of the remaining two tractates (3 and 4), the first has been called questionably gnostic, and only the second seems to contain distinctively gnostic ideas. Thus, when the contents of the codex as a whole are considered, one has the impression of a miscellaneous collection of spiritual pieces without any clear ideological tendency running throughout. The one common theme may be the ultimate fate of the individual—the theme with which *Asclepius* 21–29, and therefore the codex as a whole, ends. There is probably no way to know how the codex found its way into a collection of predominantly gnostic works.